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Determinants of the brand equity

A verification approach in the beverage industry in Turkey

Beverage
industry in
Turkey

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Abstract

Purpose – This research study aims to examine the practicality and application of a customer-based brand equity model, based on Aaker's well-known conceptual framework of brand equity.

Design/methodology/approach – The study employed structural equation modelling to investigate the causal relationships between the dimensions of brand equity and brand equity itself. It specifically measured the way in which consumers' perceptions of the dimensions of brand equity affected the overall brand equity evaluations. Data were collected from a sample of university students in Turkey.

Findings – The study concludes that brand loyalty is the most influential dimension of brand equity. Weak support is found for the brand awareness and perceived quality dimensions.

Research limitations/implications – While it is acknowledged that student samples are normally an unreliable basis for conclusions and predictions to be applied to consumers in general, it is considered that they were an appropriate group for this study, given that the subject was beverages.

Practical implications – Implications for brand managers and marketing planners are discussed. Marketing managers should consider the relative importance of brand equity dimensions in their overall brand equity evaluations.

Originality/value – Branding plays an important role in contemporary marketing, and is the focus of much literature, both academic and professional. This study contributes to the body of knowledge.

Keywords Brand equity, Brand loyalty, Brand awareness, Linear structure equation modelling, Drinks, Turkey

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

One of the most popular and potentially important marketing concepts which has been extensively discussed by both academicians and practitioners over the past decade is brand equity. One of the reasons for its popularity is its strategic role and importance in gaining competitive advantage and in strategic management decisions. Brand equity, when correctly and objectively measured, is the appropriate metric for evaluating the long-run impact of marketing decisions (Simon and Sullivan, 1993). Positive customer-based brand equity, in turn, can lead to greater revenue, lower costs, and higher profits; and it has direct implications for the firm's ability to command higher prices, customers' willingness to seek out new distribution channels, the effectiveness of marketing communications, and the success of brand extensions and licensing opportunities (Keller, 2003).

Although several authors have elaborated on the definition and content of brand equity, the number of studies which empirically test its proposed constructs is limited. One particular study by Yoo *et al.* (2000) has attempted to empirically test and operationalize one of the well-known conceptual brand equity models which was



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developed by Aaker (1991). They developed a multidimensional, customer-based brand equity scale using Aaker's (1991) four theoretically defined dimensions. In an attempt to explore the generalizability of the brand equity measurement devised by Yoo *et al.* (2000), by re-testing the most popularly adopted brand equity dimensions, this study set out to determine whether the results would concur in the case of a different product, country, sample profile and methodology.

Literature review

What is brand equity?

The content and meaning of brand equity have been debated in a number of different ways and for a number of different purposes, but so far no common viewpoint has emerged (Vazquez *et al.*, 2002; Keller, 2003). It can be discussed from the perspective of the manufacturer, retailer, or the consumer. While manufacturers and retailers are interested in the strategic implications of the brand equity, investors are more sympathetic for a financially defined concept (Cobb-Walgren and Ruble, 1995). Proponents of the financial perspective define brand equity as the total value of a brand which is a separable asset – when it is sold, or included in a balance sheet (Feldwick, 1996). Alternative definitions adopting the same perspective consider brand equity as the incremental cash flows which accrue to branded products over unbranded products (Simon and Sullivan, 1993).

When marketing practitioners use the term “brand equity”, they tend to mean brand description or brand strength, referred to as “customer brand equity” to distinguish it from the asset valuation meaning (Wood, 2000). The customer-based brand equity definitions approach the subject from the perspective of the consumer – whether it is an individual or an organization. They contend that for a brand to have value it must be valued by consumers. Then, the power of a brand lies in what customers have learned, felt, seen, and heard about the brand as a result of their experiences over time (Keller, 2003). If the brand has no meaning to the consumer, none of the other definitions is meaningful (Keller, 1993; Cobb-Walgren and Ruble, 1995; Rio *et al.*, 2001a). Thus, a customer-based definition of brand equity is given by Keller (2003, p. 60) as “the differential effect that brand knowledge has on consumer response to the marketing of that brand”.

While there are several other definitions of brand equity from different perspectives, one of the most generally accepted and the most comprehensive (Motameni and Shahrokhi, 1998) is “a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name and symbol, that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or to that firm's customers” (Aaker, 1991, p. 15).

Brand equity measurements

Studies regarding the measurement of brand equity can be grouped mainly in two distinct categories. As was the case with the definitions, some authors have studied the financial aspects of the brand equity measurement, whereas others have focused on the customer-based measurement issues. Among the financially-oriented studies, Simon and Sullivan (1993) emphasized macro and micro approaches as an estimation technique extracting the value of brand equity from the value of the firm's other assets. They first assign an objective value to a company's brands and relate this value to the determinants of brand equity according to the macro approach. Then, the micro

approach isolates changes in brand equity at the individual brand level. In a similar manner to Simon and Sullivan's study, Motameni and Shahrokhi (1998) proposed a global brand equity valuation model quantifying all the components and applying the generally accepted financial techniques. Among other valuation studies, Grand Metropolitan has valued newly acquired brands by determining the difference between the acquisition price and fixed assets. Interbrand Group, on the other hand, has used a subjective multiplier of brand profits based on the brand's performance along seven dimensions: leadership, stability, market stability, internationality, trend, support and protection (Keller, 1993).

Customer-based brand equity measurement studies are constructed mainly on conceptual constructs proposed by management gurus. While Aaker (1991) focused on five brand equity dimensions – brand awareness, brand associations, brand loyalty, perceived quality, and other proprietary brand assets – Keller (1993) adopted two basic approaches (direct and indirect) to measuring customer-based brand equity emphasizing two constructs: brand awareness and brand image. The indirect approach tries to identify potential sources of customer-based brand equity: distribution channels, the effectiveness of marketing communications, and the success of brand extension by measuring brand awareness and the characteristics and relationships among brand associations. The direct approach focuses on consumer response to different elements of the firm's marketing program (Keller, 2003).

Silverman *et al.* (1999) explored the relationship between customer-based and financial/market-based brand equity measurements. The overall implication of customer-based research suggests that measures of customer-based brand perceptions are accurate reflections of brand performance in the marketplace. Customer-based brand equity, in this respect, is the driving force for incremental financial gains to the firm (Lassar *et al.*, 1995).

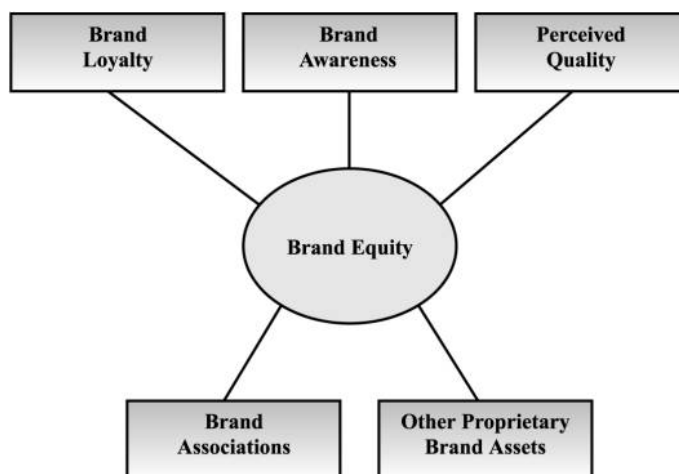
A conceptual framework for measuring customer-based brand equity

Brand equity is a multi-dimensional concept and a complex phenomenon, some dimensions of which have been empirically tested in the literature. Among several brand equity models in the literature, we have chosen that constructed by Aaker (1991), the most commonly cited, which is shown in Figure 1. It has been probed in a number of empirical investigations (Eagle and Kitchen, 2000; Yoo *et al.*, 2000; Faircloth *et al.*, 2001; Washburn and Plank, 2002), the most critical parts of which involve the verification of the dimensions on which brand equity is based.

As depicted in the figure, Aaker built his model of brand equity on five dimensions. Each is briefly reviewed below, together with the related hypotheses which have been separately tested in the succeeding sections of this study.

Brand loyalty

In brand loyalty research, the main challenge centres on defining the brand loyalty construct and its measurement. Javalgi and Moberg (1997) defined brand loyalty according to behavioural, attitudinal, and choice perspectives. While behavioural perspective is based on the amount of purchases for a particular brand, attitudinal perspective incorporates consumer preferences and dispositions towards brands. Definitions regarding the choice perspective focus on the reasons for purchases or the factors that may influence choices. These brand loyalty definitions were empirically



Source: Aaker (1991)

Figure 1.
A conceptual framework
for brand equity

researched under three major categories: multi domain approach, behavioural approach, and attitudinal approach (Rundle-Thiele and Bennett, 2001).

Aaker (1991) defines brand loyalty as a situation which reflects how likely a customer will be to switch to another brand, especially when that brand makes a change, either in price or in product features. Keller (2003), on the other hand, examines brand loyalty under the term “brand resonance” which refers to the nature of customer-brand relationship and the extent to which customers feel that they are “in sync” with the brand. Customers, with true brand resonance, have a high degree of loyalty, actively seek means to interact with the brand and share their experiences with others.

These definitions of brand loyalty point to a direct relationship between brand loyalty and brand equity where brand loyalty is often known to be a core dimension of brand equity (Aaker, 1991).

Based on the above definitions and suggested relationships in the literature, the following hypothesis is formulated:

H1. Brand loyalty has a significant positive direct effect on brand equity.

Perceived quality

Perceived quality is defined as “the customer’s perception of the overall quality or superiority of a product or service with respect to its intended purpose, relative to alternatives” (Zeithaml, 1988). It is a competitive necessity and many companies today have turned customer-driven quality into a potent strategic weapon. They create customer satisfaction and value by consistently and profitably meeting customer’s needs and preferences for quality. Kotler (2000) draws attention to the intimate connection among product and service quality, customer satisfaction, and company profitability.

Based on these points and the brand equity literature, the relationship between quality and brand equity is hypothesized as follows:

H2. Perceived quality has a significant direct effect on brand equity.

Brand awareness

Brands vary in the amount of power and value they have in the marketplace. At one extreme are brands that are not known by most users. At the other extreme, there are brands for which buyers have a fairly high degree of brand awareness. (Aaker, 1991, p. 61) defines brand awareness as “the ability of the potential buyer to recognize and recall that a brand is a member of a certain product category”. According to Keller (2003), brand awareness plays an important role in consumer decision making by bringing three advantages; these are learning advantages, consideration advantages, and choice advantages. Customer-based brand equity occurs when the consumer has a high level of awareness and familiarity with the brand and holds some strong, favourable, and unique brand associations in memory. Thus, the third hypothesis is as follows:

H3. Brand awareness has a significant direct effect on brand equity.

Brand association

A brand association is “anything linked in memory to a brand” (Aaker, 1991, p. 109). Brand associations may be seen in all forms and reflect characteristics of the product or aspects independent of the product itself (Chen, 2001). The importance of brand name associations, for instance, is emphasized by Rio *et al.* (2001a) in obtaining differential advantages. Product associations and organizational associations are taken as the two mostly referred categories according to Chen’s (2001) brand association typology.

Associations represent basis for purchase decisions for brand loyalty, and also create value to the firm and its customers. Aaker (1991) has listed these benefits as follows: helping to process/retrieve information, differentiating the brand, generating a reason to buy, creating positive attitudes/feelings, and providing a basis for extensions. Rio *et al.* (2001b) proposes that brand associations are a key element in brand equity formation and management. In this respect, high brand equity implies that consumers have strong positive associations with respect to the brand.

Thus, the fourth hypothesis is:

H4. Brand association has a significant direct effect on brand equity.

Methodology

A research framework was designed to test the above hypothesized relationships in a marketing environment. For the purpose, the beverage market in Turkey was targeted. Having considered the fact that the likelihood of beverage consumption was strongly linked to the 20-30 age segment in the market, the target population of interest was defined as the students of a local university.

It has been widely asserted that student samples do not have the sufficient representative power for validity and generalizability of the general population or “real people”. However, the use of student respondents are deemed acceptable and even desirable in some cases particularly when they constitute the major consumer segment for the selected product (Yoo *et al.*, 2000). Thus, a self-administered structured questionnaire was developed to collect quantitative data pertaining to the various

aspects of brand equity and its determinants. At the end of the data collection period, a total of 255 usable questionnaires were obtained, which is well above the critical sample size of 200 for developing structural equation models (Hair *et al.*, 1998).

The respondent students provided evaluations on 16 attributes across the entire spectrum of ways in which they might interact with and evaluate the regarding product. The attributes were derived from the empirical study of Yoo *et al.* (2000) which tested the Aaker's (1991) conceptual brand equity model. The reason is that their scale development studies have brought both the academics and practitioners closer to a universally accepted measure of customer-based brand equity and the structural model of brand equity creation process has important implications for marketing managers (Washburn and Plank, 2002).

On the survey instrument, respondents were asked to rate Product X on a ten-point scale of agreement-disagreement, indicating how well Product X performs on that attribute, rather than the five-point response scale employed by Yoo *et al.* (2000). The advantage of using an interval scale is that it permits the researchers to use a variety of statistical techniques which can be applied to nominal and ordinal scale data in addition to the arithmetic mean, standard deviation, product-moment correlations, and other statistics commonly used in marketing research (Malhotra, 1999).

Findings

In order to test the reliability of the overall scale and each of the brand equity dimensions, Cronbach's alpha scores were evaluated. The result was that one perceived quality statement and one overall brand equity statement (QL6 and OBE1) were excluded from the final scale. The reliability comparison of the original scale developed by Yoo *et al.* (2000) and the scale used in this study is depicted in Table I. As will be noticed in the table, brand awareness and association items were united (0.94) in the original study.

Construct validity of the instrument is justified because the measures were developed from a theoretical framework that was derived from an extensive literature review. Convergent and discriminant validity of the constructs were tested by principal components analysis, using varimax rotation. According to the four dimensions proposed by Aaker (1991) in the brand equity literature, we have chosen a four factor solution that reduced the 13 variables to four factors ($\alpha = 0.91$), with eigenvalues greater than 1.0 except the brand association dimension which has an eigenvalue less than one. These four factors explained 74.26 per cent of the total variance. Table II lists the factors in the order in which they were extracted from the data. One of the brand awareness statements (AW3) was grouped in the perceived quality dimension.

When the correlations of the statements were examined, a high correlation was detected between this statement (AW3) and perceived quality rather than other

Table I.
Reliability comparison of
the two brand equity
scales

Brand equity dimensions	Scale of Yoo <i>et al.</i> (2000)	Scale used in this study
Perceived quality (QL)	0.93	0.89
Brand loyalty (LO)	0.90	0.85
Brand associations (ASSC)	0.94	0.62
Brand awareness (AW)		0.74
Brand equity	0.93	0.87
Overall scale	-	0.91

Factor	Factor interpretation (% variance explained)	Loading	Brand equity attribute
<i>F1</i>	<i>Perceived quality (49 per cent)</i>		
(QL1)		0.820	X is of high quality
(QL2)		0.820	The likely quality of X is extremely high
(QL4)		0.780	The likelihood that X is reliable is very high
(QL5)		0.700	X must be of very good quality
(AW3)		0.660	I am aware of X
<i>F2</i>	<i>Brand awareness (11 per cent)</i>		
(AW2)		0.786	I can recognize X among competing brands
(ASSC1)		0.756	Some characteristics of X come to my mind quickly
(AW1)		0.739	I know what X looks like
<i>F3</i>	<i>Brand loyalty (8 per cent)</i>		
(LO3)		0.866	I would not buy other brands, if X is available at the store
(LO2)		0.851	X would be my first choice
(LO1)		0.586	I consider myself to be loyal to X
<i>F4</i>	<i>Brand associations (6 per cent)</i>		
(ASSC3)		0.874	I have difficulty in imagining X in my mind
(ASSC2)		0.602	I can quickly recall the logo of X

Table II.
Results of the factor
analysis: factors,
variances, loadings, and
statements

awareness statements (Table III). Similarly, one of the brand association statements (ASSC1) was also highly correlated with awareness statements and therefore grouped in the brand awareness factor.

Estimating a path model with structural equation modelling

The next stage in the research involved testing of a series of causal relationships between brand equity and its determinants. Thus, product X's perceived quality, brand loyalty, brand associations, and brand awareness were taken as the valid predictors of customer-based brand equity. To assess the statistical significance of the model, structural equation modelling was used. The proposed relationships in the model which were based on a theoretical perspective were portrayed in a path diagram in Figure 2. Perceived quality, brand loyalty, brand associations, and brand awareness

	(QL1)	(QL2)	(QL4)	(QL5)	(LO1)	(LO2)	(LO3)	(AW1)	(AW2)	(AW3)	(ASSC1)	(ASSC2)	(ASSC3)
(QL1)	1.000												
(QL2)	0.819	1.000											
(QL4)	0.692	0.682	1.000										
(QL5)	0.569	0.584	0.619	1.000									
(LO1)	0.373	0.388	0.331	0.309	1.000								
(LO2)	0.491	0.483	0.416	0.361	0.583	1.000							
(LO3)	0.480	0.488	0.378	0.359	0.553	0.831	1.000						
(AW1)	0.468	0.493	0.506	0.437	0.527	0.523	0.539	1.000					
(AW2)	0.435	0.442	0.485	0.433	0.506	0.461	0.408	0.661	1.000				
(AW3)	0.499	0.526	0.507	0.541	0.213	0.286	0.281	0.402	0.379	1.000			
ASSC1	0.476	0.496	0.480	0.373	0.529	0.501	0.475	0.665	0.588	0.373	1.000		
ASSC2	0.386	0.382	0.399	0.460	0.283	0.360	0.358	0.482	0.358	0.398	0.454	1.000	
ASSC3	0.232	0.232	0.265	0.352	0.220	0.239	0.264	0.327	0.277	0.309	0.226	0.383	1.000

Table III.
Correlation matrix for
statements

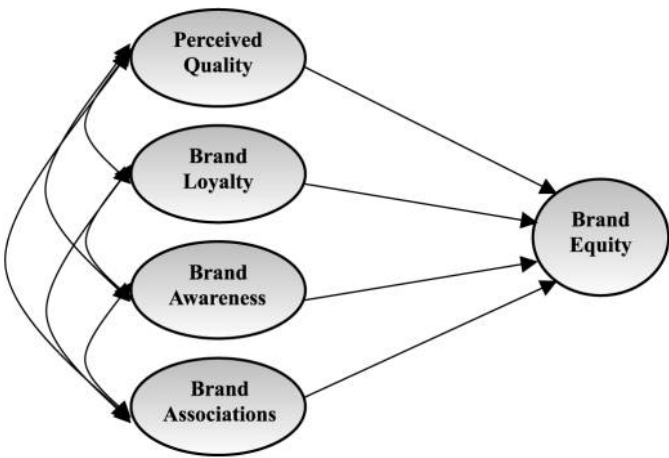


Figure 2.
Path diagram of the
conceptual model

were all taken as the exogenous variables while brand equity was the endogenous variable. Here, all of the four exogenous variables were proposed to be inter-correlated. Although the evaluative dimensions are proposed to be distinct, it is recognized that some perceptions are shared, and thus there are correlations among the constructs.

The design of the study assured independent and random responses. However, the 16 variables (13 attributes and three overall brand equity measures) were tested according to their distributional characteristics, particularly normality and kurtosis. No variable was found to have significant departure from normality or pronounced kurtosis, and thus all 16 variables were deemed suitable for use.

SEM results

The results of the SEM analyses were first examined for insensible or theoretically inconsistent estimates. In this respect, the existence of the negative error variances, standardized coefficients exceeding or very close to 1.0, or very large standard errors were checked (Hair *et al.*, 1998). The results revealed no existence of any of these offending problems (Tables IV and V).

Regarding SEM applications, Hair *et al.* (1998) asserts that there are three most basic measures of absolute fit of the model: the likelihood-ratio chi-square, the

Table IV.
Correlations among the
exogenous constructs
(*t* values in parentheses)

Exogenous constructs	Exogenous constructs			
	Perceived quality	Brand loyalty	Brand associations	Brand awareness
Perceived quality	1.00			
Brand loyalty	0.59 (12.51)	1.00		
Brand associations	0.54 (2.75)	0.44 (2.67)	1.00	
Brand awareness	0.69 (16.39)	0.69 (16.49)	0.61 (2.79)	1.00

goodness-of-fit index, and the root-mean-square residual. In the present study, the chi-square value of 252.50 with 94 degrees of freedom was found to be statistically significant at ($p < 0.00$) level (Table VI). The comparative fit index (CFI) value of 0.98 is at a marginal acceptance level, as is the root mean square residual (RMSR) value of 0.43. The root mean square error of approximation has a value of 0.072, which falls inside the acceptable range of 0.08 or less. Thus, all of the absolute fit measures indicate that the model is marginally acceptable at best.

Apart from the model's general fit for the data, it is also important to test its parameters. The significance tests for the structural model parameters are the basis for accepting or rejecting the proposed relationships between exogenous and endogenous constructs (Hair *et al.*, 1998). Although the four exogenous constructs (perceived quality, brand loyalty, brand associations, and brand awareness) were proposed to be the antecedents of brand equity, the estimated model results provided strong support for only one of the four hypotheses (Figure 3). *H1*, which underlined the positive and direct role of brand loyalty in affecting brand equity was accepted as its coefficient was significant and had the appropriate sign. However, the other three constructs (perceived quality, brand association, and brand awareness) had very low or negative parameter estimates and were deemed not statistically significant. The estimated coefficients do not support the hypotheses *H2*, *H3* and *H4*. Therefore, as far as the present empirical research is concerned, perceived quality, brand awareness, and brand associations do not have a direct significant influence on brand equity.

Table V.
Structural equation
coefficients

Endogenous construct	Perceived quality	Exogenous constructs		Brand associations	Structural equation fit (R^2)
		Brand loyalty	Brand awareness		
Brand equity	0.06	0.58	0.05	0.01	0.42

Goodness-of-fit measure	Estimated model
-------------------------	-----------------

Absolute fit measures

Likelihood-ratio chi-square (χ^2)	212.50
Degrees of freedom	94.0
Non-centrality parameter (NCP)	124.37
Goodness-of-fit index (GFI)	0.90
Root mean square residual (RMSR)	0.43
Root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA)	0.072
Expected cross-validation index (ECVI)	1.19

Incremental fit measures

Adjusted goodness of fit index (AGFI)	0.86
Tucker-Lewis index (TLI) or (NNFI)	0.97
Normed fit index (NFI)	0.96

Parsimonious fit measures

Parsimonious norm fit index (PNFI)	0.75
Parsimonious goodness of fit index (PGFI)	0.62
Model (AIC)	302.38

Table VI.
Goodness of fit measures
for the estimated model

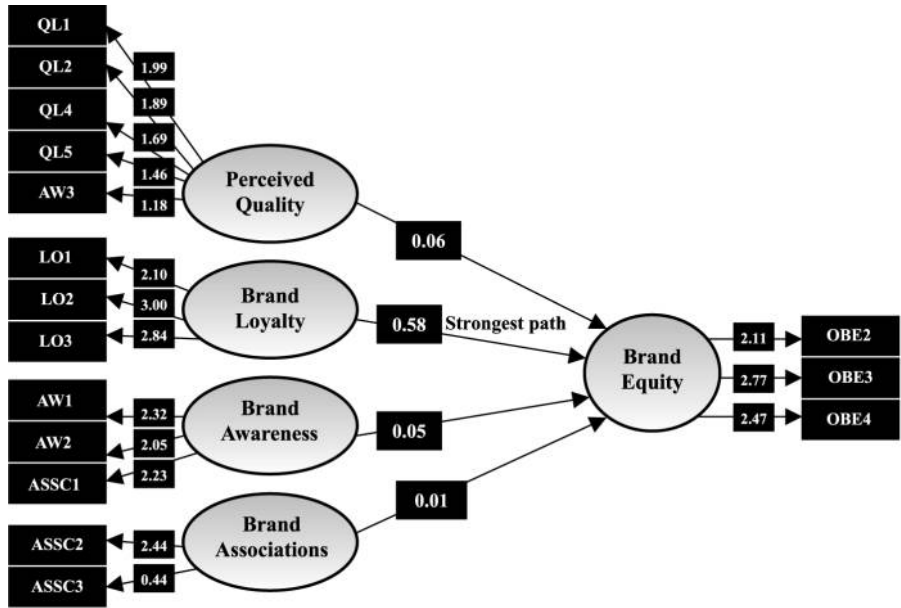


Figure 3.
Path diagram depicting
the confirmed
relationships of the
constructs

It should be noted, however, that the correlations of the four exogenous constructs were significant and all positive (Table IV). This suggests that these constructs are somehow interlinked with one another and cannot be completely isolated from the whole brand equity phenomenon. This is also supported by the regression equation in Table V, in which the combined effect of these four factors explains 42 per cent of the total variance in brand equity.

Discussion and managerial implications

This study has taken a fresh look at a familiar phenomenon, branding, which receives continuous attention from academic researchers, managers and media commentators. This interest is best demonstrated by such indicators as the appearance of special journal issues and conferences devoted to various aspects of branding. The specific topics handled in this context include brand strategy and management, brand identity, brand image, brand names, brand extensions, and brand equity.

The main focus of this study, brand equity, has been defined in several ways by different stakeholders. Strategic, financial, and customer implications of brand equity have resulted in the emergence of different definitions. However, the most comprehensive and widely accepted definition has come from Aaker (1991, p. 15) who defined it as “a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name and symbol that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or to that firm’s customers”. Despite this richness in conceptual and operational definitions and models for brand equity, there is a marked scarcity of quantitative research examining its constructs based on solid empirical data.

This study therefore aimed to test the applicability of the Aaker’s brand equity model, as the most common conceptual framework among several. It also set out to

verify the findings of a previous study by Yoo *et al.* (2000), but this time in a different country and industrial context. Even though our findings do not completely support all of Aaker's brand equity dimensions, brand loyalty was found to have a dominant effect on brand equity, which does parallel the findings of Yoo *et al.* Furthermore, brand awareness and brand association dimensions were not clearly dispersed, as in the previous research, suggesting that they are inter-related concepts and the scale has not enough discriminatory power for explaining the conceptual dimensions. In contrast to their findings, the empirical data and the statistical tests in this study did not give enough support to the existence of a direct causal relationship between the three dimensions – brand awareness, brand associations, and perceived quality – and brand equity. However, observed pairwise comparisons of the brand equity model dimensions suggested that there is a correlation between brand loyalty, brand awareness and perceived quality. Moreover, brand awareness and brand associations were found to be correlated.

Two implications can be derived from the findings. The first is that marketing managers should concentrate their efforts primarily on brand loyalty which, if increased, will contribute positively to their firm's brand equity. Brand loyalty has several important strategic benefits to the firms, such as gaining high market share and new customers, supporting brand extensions, reducing marketing costs, and strengthening brand to the competitive threats. Another point that might be considered is the inter-correlations between the constructs. Especially the relation between brand loyalty, brand awareness and perceived quality constructs. According to Aaker (1991), while brand awareness builds the familiarity-liking sight and is a signal of substance/commitment, perceived quality acts as a differentiation tool. As a result we suggest that on concentrating brand loyalty, managers should not undervalue the effects of brand awareness and perceived quality to brand loyalty.

The second implication is for academics and researchers, that further quantitative research is needed to identify the determinants of brand equity using cross-country and cross-industry applications. This would also provide a new perspective to test for brand by country effects. Finally, brand loyalty is, like brand equity, a complex construct in itself, which needs to be disaggregated if it is to be clearly understood.

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